



UNEARTHED ARCANA CURSES (FOILED AGAIN)

By Peter Schaefer

Illustration by Kent Williams

Editor's Note: This article kicks off a new feature in Dragon and Dungeon magazines. "Unearthed Arcana" will explore topics which aren't easily incorporated into the formal structure of the DUNGEONS & DRAGONS game, replace existing rules with variants, or extend the game in other unofficial, experimental ways. For more on "Unearthed Arcana," see this month's Dragon editorial.

Curses are a traditional element of fantasy stories, legends, and myths. The princess is cursed to sleep until rescued. A titan lashes out with his death curse as he is killed. The devil curses a mortal to spill worms from his mouth if he tries to speak of their bargain. Until the hero can overcome the curse, he or she must struggle beneath its weight.

This article focuses on curses that impede the subject's daily habits and pursuit of goals. Larger curses are a matter of story arcs, or entire campaigns, such as the kingdom cursed to remain under a rain-cloud until the young prince consents to marry the hideous sorceress.

Curses use the same rules as diseases once a creature has been cursed. A curse has a track similar to the disease track. A cursed creature makes an Arcana, Nature, or Religion check after each extended rest to determine the character's progression on the curse track. The relevant skill varies based on what is thematic for the curse: a wizard's curse requires Arcana; a forest spirit's curse requires Nature; an angel's divine curse requires Religion.

A cursed character cannot be cured by successful use of the appropriate skill. Most curses end when certain conditions are met, either relative to the target or in some absolute terms. Included with each curse is a suggested end condition. Individualizing end conditions to a specific game or plot makes the curse more engaging. The Remove Affliction ritual is

another method for removing curses on a character. Sometimes, the creature that applied the curse can remove it.

EXAMPLE CURSES

Forestfoe Curse

Level 4 Curse

The sprightly forest spirit looks down from a branch high above. "You are no longer welcome in Father Burl's domain! Wheresoever you walk, the forest will trip you, tug at your clothes, and cast you down!"

Stage 1: While affected by stage 1, squares adjacent to a tree are difficult terrain for the target, and travel through forests and wooded terrain takes the target twice as long.

Stage 2: While affected by stage 2, squares within 3 squares of a tree are difficult terrain for the target, and travel through forests and wooded terrain takes the target twice as long.

Stage 3: While affected by stage 3, squares within 5 squares of a tree are difficult terrain for the target, and travel through forests and wooded terrain takes the target twice as long. Additionally, when the target is hit by an attack while in such a square, he or she is knocked prone.

Check: At the end of each extended rest, the target makes a Nature check if he or she is at stage 1, 2, or 3.

9 or lower: The stage of the curse increases by one.

10-13: No change.

14 or higher: The stage of the curse decreases by one (if at stage 1, no change occurs).

Ending the Curse: A spirit of the forest chooses to release the target from the curse.

Fire's Foe Curse

Level 5 Curse

The defeated spellcaster stares at you with hatred. "Beware flame henceforth—you will attract it until you become a walking inferno."

Stage 1: While affected by stage 1, the target takes an additional 5 fire damage when targeted by a fire effect.

Stage 2: While affected by stage 2, the target takes ongoing 5 fire damage while within 1 square of a fire effect (save ends).

Stage 3: While affected by stage 3, the target takes ongoing 5 fire damage when targeted by a fire effect (save ends). The target takes 5 fire damage when an adjacent creature is the target of a fire effect. The target takes 5 fire damage if it ends its turn adjacent to any fire the size of a candle flame or larger.

Check: At the end of each extended rest, the target makes an Arcana check if he or she is at stage 1, 2, or 3.

9 or lower: The stage of the curse increases by one.

10-14: No change.

15 or higher: The stage of the curse decreases by one (if at stage 1, no change occurs).

Ending the Curse: The target is granted clemency by a fire archon or a natural spirit of fire.

Satyr's Dancing Curse

Level 6 Curse

"Your feet will want to dance," the satyr had said. Whenever you lose control, you begin to sway and move to a rhythm only you can hear.

Stage 1: While affected by stage 1, the target slides 1 square in a random direction when the target starts his or her turn dazed.

Stage 2: While affected by stage 2, the target slides 2 squares in a random direction when the target starts his or her turn dazed.

Stage 3: While affected by stage 3, the target slides 4 squares in a random direction when the target starts his or her turn dazed.

Check: At the end of each extended rest, the target makes a Arcana check if he or she is at stage 1, 2, or 3.

10 or lower: The stage of the curse increases by one.

11-13: No change.

14 or higher: The stage of the curse decreases by one (if at stage 1, no change occurs).

Ending the Curse: The target saves the life of a satyr or wins a kiss from an eladrin princess.

Speechbane Curse

Level 8 Curse

You've learned what you sought to learn, but the warlock has the last words on that subject. "You will find it impossible to pass on the knowledge you just gained, fool."

In all three stages, when the target tries to communicate about a subject forbidden by the curse-giver, the target begins vomiting maggots until the target stops trying to communicate about the forbidden subject. Additional effects are noted below.

Stage 1: The target is stunned until the end of the turn when he or she stops trying to communicate about the forbidden subject.

Stage 2: The target is stunned (save ends).

Stage 3: The target is stunned and takes ongoing 10 damage (save ends both).

Check: At the end of each extended rest, the target makes an Arcana check if he or she is at stage 1, 2, or 3.

11 or lower: The stage of the curse increases by one.

12-15: No change.

16 or higher: The stage of the curse decreases by one (if at stage 1, no change occurs).

Ending the Curse: The target goes a year and a day without speaking, or consumes food prepared by the creature that placed the curse.

Curse of Rage

Level 12 Curse

You weren't sure what the spirit of corrupted nature had meant when it promised you that even your allies would come to know you as an enemy. As you strike at your ally with uncontrollable rage, however, it becomes tragically clear.

Stage 1: While affected by stage 1, when the target starts his or her next turn after taking a critical hit, he or she makes a melee basic attack or a charge attack against the nearest valid ally.

Stage 2: While affected by stage 2 and while the target is bloodied, he or she makes a melee basic attack or a charge attack against the nearest valid ally at the start of the target's turn.

Stage 3: While affected by stage 3, when the target starts his or her next turn after being hit by an attack, he or she makes a melee basic attack or a charge attack against the nearest valid ally.

Check: At the end of each extended rest, the target makes a Nature check if he or she is at stage 1, 2, or 3.

13 or lower: The stage of the curse increases by one.

14-19: No change.

20 or higher: The stage of the curse decreases by one (if at stage 1, no change occurs).

Ending the Curse: The target slays the creature that placed the curse or permanently ends a violent threat against a peaceful community.

Curse of Isolation

Level 16 Curse

The priest spoke these words to you only minutes ago: "You choose not to see the inevitable. Perhaps, if you cannot see and hear the life around you, you will have time to think about your choice."

Stage 1: While affected by stage 1, the target takes a -5 penalty on Insight and Perception checks and on passive Insight and Perception.

Stage 2: While affected by stage 2, roll one die after each extended rest and short rest. On an even roll, the target is blinded until the next rest. On an odd roll, the target is deafened until the next rest.

Stage 3: While affected by stage 3, the target is blinded and deafened.

Check: At the end of each extended rest, the target makes a Religion check if he or she is at stage 1, 2, or 3.

15 or lower: The stage of the curse increases by one.

16-21: No change.

22 or higher: The stage of the curse decreases by one (if at stage 1, no change occurs).

Ending the Curse: The target goes a year and a day without seeing or hearing any creature, or the target consumes the eye of a beholder.

Curse of Angelic Torment Level 19 Curse

Time slows. With a dozen wounds dripping divine blood, the angel looks at you, and you feel your soul resound with the promise of infinite torment.

Stage 1: While affected by stage 1, a silver mask of the angel's face appears near the target unpredictably, speaking uncomfortable truths and making dire predictions.

Stage 2: While affected by stage 2, a silver mask of the angel's face appears near the target unpredictably, speaking uncomfortable truths and making dire predictions. The target cannot score critical hits.

Stage 3: While affected by stage 3, a silver mask of the angel's face appears near the target unpredictably, speaking uncomfortable truths and making dire predictions. When the target scores a critical hit, bonus damage from that attack is applied to the cursed character rather than to the target of the attack.

Check: At the end of each extended rest, the target makes a Religion check if he or she is at stage 1, 2, or 3.

16 or lower: The stage of the curse increases by one.

17-23: No change.

24 or higher: The stage of the curse decreases by one (if at stage 1, no change occurs).

Ending the Curse: The target is blessed by the god whom the angel serves or by a superior angel.

Death Titan's Curse Level 25 Curse

The last of the death titan's captured soul flies from his grasp, and he falls to his knees. With his last breath, he utters, "Let even the slightest touch bring you great pain."

The target of the Death Titan's Curse feels intense pain when any other creature is adjacent. Additional effects are noted below.

Stage 1: While affected by stage 1, the target gains vulnerable 5 to all damage while adjacent to any other creature.

Stage 2: While affected by stage 2, the target gains vulnerable 10 to all damage while adjacent to any other creature.

Stage 3: While affected by stage 3, the target gains vulnerable 15 to all damage while adjacent to any other creature.

Stage 4: While affected by stage 4, the target is weakened and gains vulnerable 15 to all damage while adjacent to any other creature.

Check: At the end of each extended rest, the target makes a Religion check if he or she is at stage 1, 2, or 3.

20 or lower: The stage of the curse increases by one.

21-28: No change.

29 or higher: The stage of the curse decreases by one (if at stage 1, no change occurs).

Ending the Curse: The target dies or is forgiven by the death titan's next of kin.

About the Author

As an RPG developer, **Peter Schaefer** worked on such books as *Adventurer's Vault 2*, *The Plane Below*, and *Player's Handbook 3*, in addition to numerous D&DI articles. But that is only a side-line, as Earth dollars do not pay for the lifestyle of a multiversal delver such as he. The wavefunction manifold alone requires a small power plant to engage. He earns his bread by mapping alternate dimensions in exchange for crystallized terajoules with which he can power his crossworld jaunts.